

Relative minors
of major keys

Each major key has a relative minor key. The relative minor to a given major key has exactly the same sharps or flats in its key signature as that major key does.

▽ **Relative minors**
The table below shows all the different possible major keys, and the relative minors to these major keys.

Key signature	Major key	Minor key
B $\flat$, E $\flat$, A $\flat$, D $\flat$, G $\flat$, C $\flat$, F $\flat$	C $\flat$ major	A $\flat$ minor
B $\flat$, E $\flat$, A $\flat$, D $\flat$, G $\flat$, C $\flat$	G $\flat$ major	E $\flat$ minor
B $\flat$, E $\flat$, A $\flat$, D $\flat$, G $\flat$	D $\flat$ major	B $\flat$ minor
B $\flat$, E $\flat$, A $\flat$, D $\flat$	A $\flat$ major	F minor
B $\flat$, E $\flat$, A $\flat$	E $\flat$ major	C minor
B $\flat$, E $\flat$	B $\flat$ major	G minor
B $\flat$	F major	D minor
No sharps or flats	C major	A minor
F $\sharp$	G major	E minor
F $\sharp$, C $\sharp$	D major	B minor
F $\sharp$, C $\sharp$, G $\sharp$	A major	F $\sharp$ minor
F $\sharp$, C $\sharp$, G $\sharp$, D $\sharp$	E major	C $\sharp$ minor
F $\sharp$, C $\sharp$, G $\sharp$, D $\sharp$, A $\sharp$	B major	G $\sharp$ minor
F $\sharp$, C $\sharp$, G $\sharp$, D $\sharp$, A $\sharp$, E $\sharp$	F $\sharp$ major	D $\sharp$ minor
F $\sharp$, C $\sharp$, G $\sharp$, D $\sharp$, A $\sharp$, E $\sharp$, B $\sharp$	C $\sharp$ major	A $\sharp$ minor

Key signatures for minor keys

The key signature for a minor key is exactly the same as the key signature for its relative major key. This is because the relative major and relative natural minor have exactly the same sharps or flats. Some examples of the key signatures for relative major and relative minor keys are shown below.

△ **Same key signature**
The key signatures for B $\flat$ major and G minor have the same flats—B $\flat$ and E $\flat$ —so they are written in exactly the same way.

△ **Same key signature**
The key signatures for E major and C $\sharp$ minor are written in the same way because they have the same sharps—F $\sharp$, C $\sharp$, G $\sharp$, and D $\sharp$.

Minor key signatures in practice

In practice, music in a minor key might use notes from that key's harmonic or melodic minor scales, as well as notes from its natural minor scale. If these notes are different from what is indicated in the key signature, they will need sharps or naturals written next to them wherever they occur in the music.

▽ **G harmonic minor scale**
This melody in G minor uses the notes of the G harmonic minor scale. B $\flat$ and E $\flat$ are in the key signature, but F $\sharp$ needs to be written wherever it occurs.

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